



Pont du Gard

A spectacular three-tiered bridge over the Gardon River, a section of the Roman aqueduct from Uzès to Nîmes

At a height of almost 164 ft (50 m) above the Gardon River, the Pont du Gard is the highest elevated aqueduct built by the Romans. It is part of a 31-mile- (50-km-) long canal that carries water from a spring near the Roman city of Ucetia (present-day Uzès) to Nemasus (Nîmes), was constructed in the 1st century CE. It makes its way through very uneven terrain, sometimes in underground channels, and crosses the valley of the Gardon.

Arched crossing

The bridge crossing the gorge was built as three tiers of archways, carrying a stone-lined water conduit on its upper level. The lower level consists of six arches

that are 72 ft (22 m) high. The middle tier has 11 similar arches, carrying an upper level of 47 smaller arches, 23 ft (7 m) high, of which 35 have survived. Over the bridge's span of 1,500 ft (456 m), the level of the aqueduct descends only 1 in (2.5 cm), a gradient of less than 1 in 18,000.

The Pont du Gard ceased to be used as an aqueduct after the end of the Roman Empire, but its function as a toll bridge over the river helped to keep it in reasonable repair, and in the 18th century, a road bridge was added to one side of the lower level. The bridge was renovated in 1885, and the roadway closed to traffic in 2000.



△ BLOCKS OF STONE

The aqueduct's stones—weighing up to 6½ tons (6 tonnes) each—were lifted into place using a human-powered winch. More than 1,000 men labored for 5 years on the construction.



< WATER FOR THE PEOPLE

Elaborately carved drinking fountains in Nîmes spouted water supplied by the aqueduct.